

CIRQL — Ring Placement Rulebook

How to lay out every ring-island so it reads as a thought-out, full-fledged RPG area (The Mana World / Stardew / Zelda quality) — not random scatter.

Researched from real practice: The Mana World's own mapping tutorial, the official RPG Maker town-mapping guide, and level-design composition theory (see **References**). This is the doc we build ring-generators against. Pairs with the locked art direction in the world-redesign memory + [CIRQL-World-Redesign-Build-Plan.md](#).

The core idea

A ring is a designed map, not a bucket of random props. Real RPG areas feel organized because everything is placed for a *reason* — either **function** (this village grew here because of that water/road/resource) or **composition** (this cluster frames that focal point). Randomly sprinkling one plant species across a band is the #1 thing that makes a map read as "computer-generated."

So the build order is always **STRUCTURE** → **PATHS** → **FILL**, never "scatter then hope":

1. **Anchors first.** Pick 3–5 focal points (the pond, the plaza/well, a landmark, the dock, one big grove). Place *those*.
 2. **Connect them.** Run a path/road between the anchors the way people would actually walk.
 3. **Grow the settlement** around one anchor (buildings facing in, clustered, short sensible paths).
 4. **Fill** the rest with nature that has *land-use logic* + composition clustering.
 5. **Leave clearings.** Negative space is a feature, not a gap to fill.
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0. The GROUND is tiles, not a flat fill (the "placed vs. part of" fix)

The biggest thing that makes our maps read as "everything is *placed on* the ground instead of *part of* it" is that the ground is one flat colour with props sitting on top. **TMW/Zelda/Stardew build the ground itself out of tiles** — textured grass, dirt, sand, tilled soil, cobble, forest-floor — with blended transitions. The ground becomes a rich *surface*, and props are fewer and purposeful. This is the fix for "flat / placed / lifeless."

DO (TMW ground rules)

- **Fill the ground layer completely, with real tiles.** TMW: "*Ground1, the lowest ground layer, has to be filled completely before the map is finished*" — never leave raw fill showing. Our textured grass tile IS that layer; don't hide it under a flat colour.
- **Use several GROUND TYPES, not one.** Grass **and** dirt paths **and** tilled farm soil **and** cobble plaza **and** a darker forest-floor under the trees. Varying the ground *type* (not just scattering props) is what reads as a real place.
- **Blend terrain edges with autotiles.** Where two ground types meet, use the pack's border/blob autotile so the edge feathers (grass fringing into dirt), never a hard blocky seam. TMW: plain ground tiles "make the ways even more blocky than they have to be" — use the grass-border autotiles. (Options: 47-piece bitmask, or the compact **dual-grid**/Wang approach.)
- **Layer it (TMW layer model):** *Ground1/2/3* (terrain) → *Fringe* (oversized props drawn relative to sprites, depth-sorted) → *Over* (treetops/roofs above the player) → *Collision* (invisible walk/block). Depth = richness.
- **A fence or wall can hide a hard edge.** Where a soil field meets grass, a fence around it hides the seam — no perfect autotile needed.
- **Paths are tiles too.** A dirt/cobble path is a *ground type* laid into the terrain (blended edges), not a prop strip — that's what makes it feel walked-on and "part of" the map.

DON'T

- Don't paint one flat colour over the whole ground and rely on props for all detail — that's the exact "placed, not part of" look.
- Don't leave a terrain type as a hard rectangle — feather it (autotile) or hide the edge (fence/wall/prop line).

Reference looks — what real TMW maps actually look like (studied their good/bad examples)

Compared TMW's own **Goodmap** vs **Badmap**:

- **Both** have **textured grass TILES** as the ground — never a flat colour. That's the baseline; our old flat-fill was below even their *bad* example.
- **Good** = trees **clustered organically** (not a grid), a **winding dirt path** with soft blended edges, an **organic water shore**, and **lighter tall-grass patches laid in as tiles** to break up the base grass.
- **Bad** = trees in a **perfect grid**, a **straight path with a hard 90° corner**, a **straight water edge**, and **uniform grass** with no tile variation.

- **The bar:** every time we build an area, ask "**is this better than The Mana World?**" — if not, fix it. Study a reference for *that specific biome* (forest/desert/rainforest/etc.) before building it, don't build from memory.
- **Mix biomes on one ring.** A ring doesn't have to be one biome — blend e.g. meadow → wetland → woodland across it (with tiled transitions). More visual interest, and it scales as rings get bigger.
- **Colour must FLOW and match the biome.** Each biome gets a cohesive palette that *matches and enhances* it (enchanted forest = lush sunlit green → deep cool teal-green shade; desert = warm sand→ochre; ember = ash→ember-glow). Flow it as **soft tonal patches** over the textured ground tiles — never a flat single colour, never hard-edged tone tiles (those fight the natural flow). Ease terrain-to-terrain colour transitions (sand greens into grass at the shore) so nothing has a hard seam.
- **Round the tile grid to the ring with a MASK.** Since the ring is a curved disk but tiles are a square grid, clip the tile ground to the true shoreline curve and let the procedural beach paint around it, colour-matched to the ground it meets — so tiles never poke past the edge and the coast reads smooth. Keep all props inside the edgepoint so none hang over the mask (a dock/reeds at the water is a deliberate exception).

1. Structure & focal points

DO

- Give every ring **3–5 focal points** where the player naturally stops (RPG Maker: "3–4 anchor points"; TMW: "set aside points where players stop and spend time, make them memorable in a small window").
- Make the focal point **stand out** — brighter, more contrast, framed by negative space and clustered props pointing at it (composition: the dominant element must not merge with the scene).
- Use **leading lines** — a road, a river/shore, a row of trees, the way a fence runs — to pull the eye toward the focal point.
- Make sure **every screen-sized frame is pleasing on its own** ("that is what players actually see in game").

DON'T

- Don't make a ring with no hierarchy where every area is equally busy — the eye has nowhere to rest and nothing to head toward.
- Don't bury the focal point in clutter or let it blend into the surrounding density.

2. Village / settlement layout

DO

- **Decide why the village exists first** (RPG Maker: "think about the purpose of the town and how it came to exist"). Fishing hamlet → by the water. Mushroom-farmers → around the fungal grove. That single decision drives *everything*.
- **Cluster buildings around a center** (a well, plaza, market, or shrine) so foot-traffic and sightlines converge.
- **Face entrances toward the action** (the plaza / road) so "ways are short and make sense."
- **Vary building size by role/wealth** — the inn/chief's house is bigger and prominent; a single villager's hut is small. Same-size houses in a row = fake.
- **Keep material consistent** with the biome/economy ("where do they get their building materials?") — one coherent building set per settlement.
- Position **work-buildings near their resource** (fisher's hut by the cove, mill by the river, farm by the open field).

DON'T

- **No grid / no straight rows of identical houses** ("the map is very square-y" is the classic failure). Stagger position, rotation, and spacing.
- Don't spread the village evenly across the whole ring — a settlement is a *dense cluster*, with wilderness between it and the next pocket.
- Don't put every door facing the same way — some variety reads as organic.

3. Roads & paths

DO

- **A path exists to connect anchors** (dock → village → pond → landmark). It has a job; it's not decoration.
- Route it **where people would actually walk** — mostly direct, with gentle bends around obstacles.
- **Line the road** with the things that belong beside a road (fences, signposts, lamp-posts, a bench, worn grass, the odd cart) so it feels travelled.

DON'T

- **No hard 90° corners** where a real path would curve, and no needless S-curves where people would walk straight (TMW + RPG Maker both call this out).

- Don't let a path dead-end for no reason, or run parallel-hugging a river the whole way (a nit we already hit).

4. Nature & biome (the part that's been reading as random)

DO

- **Break up every straight line and grid.** "Trees don't grow in grid patterns; rivers, ridges and shores should never be perfectly straight" (TMW). Our SDF pond/shore already does this — keep props off grids too.
- **Cluster plants in odd-numbered groups** (rule of threes) with varied spacing — a copse of 3–5 trees, then open ground, then a clump of 7 mushrooms. Clusters read far better than an even scatter (composition rule: "small groups are more pleasing than randomly scattered props").
- **Three tiers of flora, spread by threes** (RPG Maker "balance by threes"): a **signature** plant (the giant mushrooms), a **secondary** (bushes/small mushrooms), and a **tertiary** ground detail (tufts, flowers, pebbles, fallen leaves). Never one species alone.
- **Density gradients, not uniform coverage** — dense near water/village/landmark, thinning to open meadow, denser again at the wild rim. Outward rings get *more* pockets, never emptier.
- **Land-use logic — each thing near what it "wants":** trees form a *grove on one side* (a forest has an edge), cattails/reeds/lily pads only at the water, rocks/boulders on higher/rougher ground, mushrooms thickest in shade near the grove, flowers in sunny open meadow and around homes.
- **Eye-catching tiles used sparingly** (TMW) — the rare bright flower, the one big boulder, a glowing mushroom. If everything is loud, nothing is.

DON'T

- **Don't ring the whole shore evenly with one prop** (our current "grove band at radius 4.5–8" is exactly the random-looking thing to kill — it's a uniform annulus of one species).
- **Don't scatter a single species uniformly** across a band — that's the signature "generated" look.
- Don't place canopy props so they overhang water, paths, or the ring edge (keep the edgepoint margin).

5. Density, variety & negative space

DO

- **Vary the ground** so open areas don't read as flat fill (TMW/RPG Maker: ground variation is the single biggest fix for empty-looking space) — our procedural moss shading covers this; add scattered tufts/detail props too.
- **Leave deliberate clearings** — a clean patch of meadow, the open ring around the pond, a village square. Negative space frames the busy bits and gives the eye rest.
- **Balance clutter by threes, spread over the map** — small storytelling details (firewood by a hut, a basket, a signpost, worn stones) that imply life.

DON'T

- Don't fill every tile. "If you have empty space you can't fill, the map is too large" — shrink the ring or add a *pocket*, don't carpet it.
- Don't repeat the same object dozens of times on one screen; don't line things up evenly.

5b. Density & detail — never leave the ground bare (the anti-empty rules)

The #1 reason a map feels "lifeless / dull / bare" (even a well-structured one) is **empty ground**. TMW, Zelda and Stardew maps are *densely textured everywhere* — open areas are still full of low ground-detail. "A clean green field of grass is empty walking space in a game." Negative space means *lower detail + no big props*, **not** blank ground.

DO

- **Carpet the ground with a fine DETAIL layer** — grass tufts, sprouts, pebbles, tiny flowers, fallen leaves, small mushrooms — everywhere the player walks. This is the single biggest fix for "empty."
- **Cluster the detail big-medium-small** — a dense patch, a medium sprinkle, a lone tuft, then a gap. An *even* coating of detail is as boring as bare ground; vary the density in waves.
- **Layer it** — ground detail (tufts/pebbles) UNDER mid props (bushes/rocks) UNDER tall props (trees/giant mushrooms, overhead). Depth reads as richness.
- **Storytelling clutter** — a few objects that say what a place is: a farm has tilled rows + a scarecrow + a basket; a home has a garden + laundry + firewood; a forest floor has logs, stumps, mushrooms, ferns.
- **Match density to the biome** — a *rainforest/grove* is thick (overlapping canopy, dense undergrowth); a *meadow* is medium (tufts + flower clumps); a *desert* is sparse-but-still-detailed (dunes, dry shrubs, bones, rocks). "Bare" is never the answer — thin biomes still have texture.

- **Give big props breathing room** — don't shove a house/tree flush against a wall or another big prop, or it reads as a flat cardboard cutout; let ground detail fill the gap around it.

DON'T

- Don't leave wide stretches of untouched base ground — that's the "empty" the owner is reacting to.
- Don't carpet detail perfectly evenly (looks like wallpaper) — cluster it.
- Don't over-detail with loud/eye-catching tiles everywhere — those stay rare; the carpet is *quiet* detail.

5c. Enclosures, farms & crops (what makes a village read as lived-in)

DO

- **Fence the yards.** Real village houses have a fenced garden/yard. Enclose a bit of ground by each home (or a shared plot) with a fence — instantly reads as "someone lives and works here."
- **Grow crops in neat rows.** A farm = **tilled soil with furrow rows + a fence + regular rows of the same crop** (here: cultivated mushrooms in rows on dark soil). Rows are the one place *regularity is correct* — crops are planted deliberately.
- **Tie the farm to the village economy** — mushroom-farmers → a mushroom field beside the hamlet; fishers → drying racks by the water. The clutter should explain how these people live.
- **Gardens & window-boxes** — flower beds inside the fences, a well/trough, benches, a cart, barrels, a stump for chopping.

5d. Breadcrumb trails — guide the player with flora & landmarks

DO

- **Lead the eye with a trail.** Line the path with flowers, lanterns, stepping-stones, tufts — a *breadcrumb trail* the player subconsciously follows from one anchor to the next (plaza → pond → grove).
- **Landmarks create "gravity."** A tall bright focal (a great glowing mushroom, a lighthouse) pulls the player toward it; place them so the player naturally orbits between anchors.
- **The triangle rule** — arrange your 3 big anchors so sightlines form triangles; the player always sees the next point of interest, never a dead flat expanse.

5e. Water features — juice the pond (never leave it bare)

A focal pond should be *lush*, not a flat puddle (researched pond design):

- **Lush shore ring** — cattails/reeds + tall water-grass + **encircling smooth stones** around the whole bank.
- **Lily pads afloat** (some with a flower) + the odd rock breaking the surface.
- **Life** — a duck swimming, a frog on the bank, fish shadows gliding *under* the surface, dragonflies/fireflies darting above.
- **Animated surface** — concentric ripple rings + sun-sparkle glints; deep-teal water with warm highlights.
- **Palette** — deep teal water + sage-green reeds + a warm accent; keep it cohesive with the biome.

5f. Keep objects WELL inside the ring

Nothing sits near the shoreline. Every placement gate uses a generous **edgepoint margin (~4+ tiles)** so props/NPCs/detail read as *on the land*, not teetering on the coast. No "rim band" of props hugging the beach. (Water-edge exceptions like a dock are deliberate.)

5g. Water clearance & no bad overlaps

- **Only water things go near water.** Animals (duck/frog) and *intended* water plants (reeds, cattails, lily pads, encircling stones, overhanging bushes) may sit in/near a pond. **Every other object keeps ~3 tiles clear of the water** — no random mushroom/tree/detail crowding the shore.
- **No prop-on-prop overlaps.** Small ground detail (pebbles, tufts, flowers) must not land on top of a cap/trunk/house — gate it against nearby big props (a rock on a mushroom's head reads as a bug).

5h. One gathering spot + a dock per ring

- **A gathering spot** — one communal **Commons** per ring (a bonfire clearing with seats, or biome equivalent), placed in an open clearing kept clear of clutter. It's where festivals / the Welcome Dance / crowd moments happen.
- **A dock** — a little jetty at the shore as the ring's departure point (a deliberate water-edge exception). Ring-to-ring sailing wires up when the world is assembled.

6. Believability & story

DO

- Every placed thing should answer "**why is it here?**" — a person, a purpose, or a natural cause put it there.
- **Put NPCs where their function is** — the fisher at the pond bank/cove, the farmer in the field, the keeper at the plaza — not floating at random coordinates.
- **Imply daily life** with clutter that tells a micro-story (tools by a workshop, laundry line, a campfire, tracks).
- **Make things interactive** where you can (TMW/RPG Maker) — a sign that reads, a bush that rustles, a critter you can pet — even tiny reactions sell the world.

DON'T

- Don't place a landmark/prop with no reason or relationship to its surroundings.

7. Borders (already handled — keep it)

- A ring needs a **designed, non-walkable border** (TMW: ~20-tile designed border). Our **procedural beach** → **sea void** rim is that border. Keep the wild rim framed (fauna fringe, the shore) rather than props running to the water's edge.

Applying it to the Shroomwood (the fix)

What's random now: giant mushrooms placed by `placeShroomGrove` as a *uniform ring band* + small mushrooms/rocks scattered around arbitrary `centers[]` + houses at hand-typed coords not organized as a village. One species dominates; no path; no clear focal hierarchy; NPCs near-arbitrary.

The redesign (STRUCTURE → PATHS → FILL):

1. **Anchors:** the **pond** (rest/beauty focal), a **village plaza** (a small clearing with a shared well/fire), one **great glowing mushroom** as a landmark, the **dock** (entry).
2. **Village = a real cluster:** 4–5 shroom houses grouped around the plaza on *one side* of the ring, entrances facing in, staggered (no row), sizes varied (a big inn-cap + small huts), a short lane linking plaza → dock and plaza → pond.
3. **The "mushroom forest" as a grove with an edge:** mass the giant mushrooms into **one dense stand** (a corner/arc), thinning outward — not an even ring. Odd-numbered clumps, varied scale.
4. **Three flora tiers:** giant mushrooms (signature) → bushes + small mushrooms (secondary) → tufts/pebbles/fallen-caps (tertiary), clustered by threes with gaps.
5. **Land-use:** cattails/lily pads only at the pond (done), rocks on a rise, mushrooms thickest in the grove's shade, a few flower/bush clumps by the houses.
6. **Clearings:** keep the open ring around the pond, an open plaza, and a clean meadow stretch — breathing room between pockets.
7. **NPCs by function:** fisher at the pond bank, a forager in the grove, a keeper at the plaza.

Net effect: you arrive at the dock, a path leads you past the pond to a real little mushroom village, with a fungal forest massed beyond it and quiet meadow between — an area that was *designed*, not sprinkled.

References

- **The Mana World — Development:Mapping Tutorial** (break up grids/straight lines, sparse eye-catching tiles, memorable focal points, designed 20-tile border, fill the ground layer): https://wiki.themanaworld.org/wiki/Development:Mapping_Tutorial and **Maps:** <https://wiki.themanaworld.org/wiki/Maps>
- **RPG Maker — official "Mapping: Towns" guide** (town purpose first, cluster around anchors, entrances face activity, vary building size/role, avoid grid/square maps, every frame pleasing): <https://www.rpgmakerweb.com/blog/mapping-towns>
- **RPG Maker forums — Mapping & Map Design tips** (avoid empty space / start small, ground variation, balance clutter by threes, interactivity): <https://forums.rpgmakerweb.com/threads/mapping-and-map-design-tips.140273/>
- **Composition in Level Design** (leading lines, focal point/dominant, negative space, cluster > scatter): <https://www.gamedeveloper.com/design/composition-in-level-design> and http://level-design.org/?page_id=2274
- **How To Design a Town** (settlement grows from its resources/economy; logical building placement; ≥1 point of interest): <https://2minutetabletop.com/how-to-design-a-town/>